

PREMISE DELTA v0.6 • THE TRUSTING FORGERY, FOURTH CUT • 2026-09-11 (DRAFT until Stephen has read it)

Sixth delta against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 with amendments v1.5 to v1.8. History: v0.1 and v0.2 rejected by two adversaries each; v0.3 REWORK / REJECT, ten findings walked and answered; v0.4 REWORK / REWORK, nine findings walked and answered; v0.5 REWORK / REWORK, Fable stating for the second time that it could not break the device on its own terms, nine findings walked and answered on 2026-09-11 (...-v0.5-disposition-2026-09-11.md). This document is v0.5 with those nine answers built in. Three of them are structural and are flagged in the text. Premise v8.1 remains in force until this survives and Stephen rules.

A note to the reviewer: sections 8 to 10 record the three previous rounds' findings and the answers now built in. Attack the answers. A finding re-raised without engaging its answer does not count.

1. The device

Before (v8.1, ruled). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter: I think one of you is planning to kill me. The locker letter, forged: I know. Chapter 7: dead women don't get surer.

After (v0.6). A woman who trusted four people completely asked them, from behind a padlocked door, to find out who had been getting into her house. She said it was none of them. Within a month the four were sure it was one of them. Violet never accuses anyone. The accusation is built at Ruby's kitchen table by the four themselves, out of true things, and the true things were chosen by the one of them who killed her. Brad does not forge her fear. He forges her trust, keeps her voice and her instruction, and salts the list so that four honest, frightened, competent people, doing what she asked, arrive at Liam. What lets them cross out her clearance is not a character reading. It is a woman who never opened her door after dark to anyone she had not known for years, a man's back in her lane at half past ten, a back door pulled shut behind him, and her own sentence that only the four knew where her spare key lived.

Everything downstream holds as ruled: the room lands on Liam, Margo keeps her silence, Brad vanishes off Kestrel Head on Day 60, Margo dies there on Day 214, the survivors accuse each other to the police, the police look properly and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. Violet

Forty-four, the best judge of a hand on the coast, and she writes everything down, dated. No will: a woman with a solicitor and death-triggered envelopes who kept meaning to make one, so her sister, as next of kin, will administer everything, which is the irony of the fight over their mother's house. She has money her friends know about and do not ask about, and she has been open-handed with it: eight years ago she set Brad up, the van and his first stock, in cash, on no paper, against Margo's advice. All four know that. **(Structural change this round: the loan is not a secret.)** What none of them but Brad and Margo know is that this autumn

she started calling it in, for the lawyer in the fight with her sister. She said so at the café once, in passing, without a name.

This autumn, two things inside her own house. Her tobacco, two a day rolled from the tin under the stairs among the paints and the garden concentrates, comes up stained through the paper; the lid is loose; the capped bottle on the shelf above has moved six inches or has not. She bins the tobacco that day and does not smoke from that tin again. And a gilded alphabet panel comes down out of her workshop roof with a ceiling board: her own alphabet, better than she has ever done it, signed with a mark that is not a name.

She carries the panel round the trade asking whose hand it is: the café, the cinema, two other signwriters. Two say yours, in a very good year, and one of them asks the obvious question: have you shown your lad? She shows him last, on Day –19, at the sheds, with the panel under her arm on its way into her store and the new padlock going on the door in front of him. He looks at it a long time and says yours, and names the R. Three yours. She locks it in while he watches. She does not stop asking because she is satisfied; she stops because she has done the thing she does with everything, written it down and locked it up for after. What she tells herself is that it cannot be his because she never taught him leaf and he never asked; what she writes is that everyone says it is hers and she did not make it. The other three never see it: they are not lettering people. Nobody in town knows Brad can gild; his boat names are painted, the leaf work at the yard was always hers, and his leaf and size come by post to his flat.

She believes someone with her spare key has been in her house. She also believes, on alternate days, that she is imagining it. She does not suspect any of the four for a second, and the reason she does not call them is not fear of them: she has nothing to show them but a loose lid and a panel three people have told her is her own, and she would rather be laughed at after she is gone than watched while she is here. So she writes it down. Her store at the slip boatsheds is one of the old brick boat stores: a bay, a steel door on a shrouded hasp, nothing visible from outside, where she kept her hull kit. It is paid a year ahead in cash to the market manager with no receipt, like everything she keeps off the books, and it is in no ledger Margo ever saw. She moves the kit to the van, fits a closed-shackle marine padlock, has four keys cut on Lantern Street, drops the packet's two off the end of the slip and writes that down too, so that nothing on her ring leads to the door. She locks the letter behind the door with the panel and her mother, and lodges four bare notes with her solicitor to be posted after her funeral. He asks; she makes a joke about her sister. Then she gets on, calmer, because it is out of her head. She does not expect it to be needed.

3. The three letters, sketched (Fable writes prose, blind)

The key letter (genuine; four identical copies; posted Saturday Day 12; three by home delivery, one to a post office box). If you've got this, I'm dead, and I'm sorry about the timing. Go to my store at the boatsheds by the slip. The padlock's new and these four keys are the only ones. Go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. Violet. Nothing else.

The locker letter (genuine; dated Day –19; Brad reads it at 07:20 on Day 14; burned in his own grate that evening with his drafts and her book). It isn't any of you four, and I'd know. Someone with my key has been in my house, or I have started imagining things, and I cannot tell which, and both frighten me. Only you four know where the spare lives. The tin: the two a day she lies about, the stain through the paper, the loose lid, the bottle on the shelf above; I don't know whether I did that; I've thrown the tobacco out. The panel: the leak, the board, her own alphabet done better than she can do it, a mark for a name; Brad says it's mine, everyone says it's mine, I didn't make it; and if I didn't, somebody has been in my roof. Mum, on the shelf in the back bedroom, facing the door one morning when I leave her facing the window; I've put her in

here. Then: each of you write down everything odd you've noticed this year, about each other and about me, however small, and read the four lists together at one table. Then the police, with something in your hands. Write legibly. Nothing about money: the calling-in is not odd to her, it is a lawyer's bill. Brad reads it and knows what the room never will: pooled, the odd things about him name a man preparing to leave (Ruby holds the marathon he called a wedding; Liam heard him price a new van from the crane cab), and the panel names a gilder.

The locker letter (forged; dated Day –19 as she dated everything; what the four read at nine that night). Her paper and her pen, taken from the workshop on Day 0 with the book; drafted from Day 1 at his own bench from what her book said she had noticed, and conformed to her true letter on the morning of Day 14, at his bench, in two hours. Her frame, kept: it isn't any of you four, and I'd know; someone with my key has been in my house, or I'm imagining it, which frightens me more; only you four know where the spare lives. Her reason for the scale, in her voice: I don't think I'm going to die. I think I'm going to be sixty and embarrassed. But I'm putting this where it can't be got at, because if I'm wrong nobody needs to know, and if I'm right you'll want to know what I noticed. If I'd told you now you'd have sat in my kitchen with a torch and I'd never have heard the end of it. The object: I have put Mum in here with this. One morning last month she was facing the door, and I leave her facing the window. Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting. Either way she is not staying on a shelf for whoever it is to stand and look at. Keep her where all four of you can see her until this is sorted. Her instruction, kept. Then, "since I'm asking you to, here's mine", bare fact only, nothing she was not present for: Liam has owned a third of the yard for eight years and lets the town think he's staff. Liam asked in March and again in July to take Mum out to the point on his boat; I said no both times. Brad told us a wedding in the spring and ran a marathon; I saw his time. His one addition: not the police. I've nothing they'd act on and I won't have them in your lives over a shelf. You four can do what they won't. Her close, kept: read this together, be careful, write legibly.

What he cut: the tin (a poisoning in her hand sends a nurse to the police through any ban) and the panel (it names a gilder). What he kept that he could have cut: her sentence about the spare, because it is true and it closes the room on itself. What he added: the ban, and three true things that lean one way. The lean is in the choosing, never in a sentence.

4. Brad on the night, and the fourteen days

He comes about the money; she pours two glasses; she goes up for the debt book; the landing. In the twenty minutes he waits he reads her book of everything, and in her hand, dated: padlock changed, four keys cut on Lantern Street, the packet's keys off the slip, four envelopes lodged with the solicitor, letter and Mum and the panel in the store. He learns that a letter exists and where, and what she had been noticing, not what she concluded. He takes the book, because it is his exemplar and it holds the only record of what he owes. He takes a sheet of her layout paper and her pen from the workshop on the way. He rinses his glass and puts it on the rack with the others; hers stays on the side. **(Structural change this round: one glass.)** Out by the back door at 22:30, pulled shut behind him and latched; the neighbour at N^o14 sees a man's back and nothing in his hands; the book is in the rucksack he brought for it. He is never in her house again.

He does not go near the store for fourteen days, and it is the least-cost choice for this man. Nobody else can open it before the keys arrive: no fifth key exists, the packet's keys are in the harbour, the store is in no record the sister receives, and a brick bay with a steel door on a shrouded hasp has no partition, roof or hinge to go through. A cut, picked or forced lock is the one event in the story that makes the police look. His method from the tin to the stairs is that nothing is ever visibly wrong. The sheds are worked from first light, so an early visit

has the same witness on any day and a torch at two in the morning is what gets remembered. His own locker in the same corridor is a reason to be there at seven, and his PO box gives him seven. From Day 1 he drafts at his own bench from the book's list. On Day 14 at 07:20 he opens her store, reads her true letter, takes it and the panel to his own locker, and drives home. By ten the draft is conformed; by two the forgery and her mother are in her store; that evening the drafts, the true letter and the book go into his own grate. The boat owner saw a signwriter at her store door at twenty past seven, carrying a board between two doors, and thought her pupil was collecting her kit.

5. The room, week by week (replaces spine rows 14 to 60 in substance)

Day 14, 21:00. Torches, the padlock, a letter in her hand and her mother beside it. Margo: she's brought her mum. Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches. Liam carries the tube to Ruby's car, footwell not boot. Read that night at Ruby's table. The first response is relief, and then the shame of relief. Liam explains March and July the moment they are read: it had been four years; I thought if somebody offered she wouldn't have to be the one to decide. Ruby names the one line that did not sound like Vi: the police one. They decide, four of them, that Violet's sister hears nothing until they know what they are looking at, because telling her means telling her that Violet kept their mother from her for four years and lied about the point. Weekly meetings agreed. The tube on Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall because that is how Liam set it down.

Day 15. The key question, because they are competent adults, and the outward look, done in one evening because her life was small enough to audit in one evening. Liam answers the key because he found her: front locked, back latched, the spare still in the meter box, one glass on the side. Number 14 told him at the funeral what she told the police on Day 1: a man's back in the lane at half past ten. Liam fitted that back door; it latches when you pull it. Nobody else in her life: no cleaner, no lodger, no tradesman (Liam did every repair in that house, including the catch), a smart meter nobody reads, a sister four years away who has never been inside, and four people who were her whole week. And the thing all four know about her that no policeman could weigh: Vi did not open her door after dark to anyone she had not known for years. So the man in the lane was let in, or let himself in with the spare, and either way he was one of a handful of people. And the letter, in her hand: only you four know where the spare lives, beside it isn't any of you. They look outward, and there is nobody there, and that is the worst thing that could have happened to them.

Meeting 1 (Day 19). The lists begin. Liam confirms the third of the yard; the letter has told one truth and earned the rest. Margo's list, as Violet asked, has the one odd thing about Violet's year that Margo knows: Vi was calling in the van money this autumn, for the lawyer. Brad confirms it before anyone can look at him, and adds what nobody can check: he had been paying her back in cash since October, about half, and he would like the rest to go to the estate, whoever that turns out to be. **(Structural change this round: Brad's candour.)** A man who volunteers his own debt at a table looking for a liar is the last man that table suspects, and the letter's odd things are about someone else. Where were we on the Monday night: Ruby on shift; Margo at home, alone, as on every night that is not a second Sunday; Liam alone at the yard; Brad at home, on foot, alone, which is the truth minus the walk. Nobody has an alibi and the quiet man has the least. Ruby says the line the room needs, and nobody answers it, because answering means saying Vi opened her door at night to a stranger: she thought she'd know, and she's dead.

Meeting 2 (Day 26). Everything odd about Violet. The shelf. Who had been in the back bedroom this year. Liam, honestly: once, the window catch, spring. Margo underlines Spring.

Meeting 3 (Day 33). March and July, again, now beside the catch, the key and the man in the lane. Brad: that's Liam, he'd have thought that. Ruby: Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her. Nobody looks at the sideboard. The room hears an ordinary explanation given quickly as one given before; it hears a kindness about her mother as an interest in the back bedroom. That is what a frightened room does to the quiet man, and it is what the later chapters indict the room for.

Meetings 4 and 5 (Days 40, 47). The lists worked against each other; Ruby drives; Brad defends Liam each time, reasonably, and loses. By Day 47 it has landed on Liam without one line of the letter having said it. Margo, alone at the sideboard for as long as it takes Ruby to say goodbye upstairs: a quarter turn of the label, and back.

Days 45 to 53. Margo. She was never the estate's accountant: the sister uses her own solicitor and her own accountant. On Day 8 Margo helped the sister with paperwork, which was handing over Violet's business books, and told her the private loan book was not among them (shrug). Around Day 45 the sister's accountant rings about that book, and Margo answers everything truthfully: Violet's private loan book; the van loan to Brad, which everyone knew; called in this autumn; Brad says about half repaid in cash. The estate writes to Brad. **Brad settles the balance he named within the week, in cash.** The sister is satisfied and the estate's interest closes. That is the arrival. Margo alone holds the shape of it: the one record that could have tested "about half" vanished from a locked house the night Violet died; the man who set his own number paid it fast and clean; and he is the man defending Liam. She has known since Day 8 that the book was gone and thought nothing of it but grief. She knows now what its absence was for, or she thinks she does. It is a reading, not a proof, and she cannot take it anywhere: an innocent man also settles promptly, an absence is not evidence, and the man it points at is the one arguing for the man the room has chosen. **Day 54, meeting 6:** she stops arguing with Brad and stops looking at the other two. Brad, who has read her true letter, knows exactly what Margo knew and when, and has just been asked for money by the estate on her account, is the only one in the room who can read that silence, and he does. **Day 60:** Kestrel Head, as ruled.

Day 82. After the room breaks, Ruby decides the sister should have her mother back. She tells her Violet had locked her in her store at the sheds, and hands her the tube. The sister has the empty store's padlock cut the same week to see what else her sister kept from her. Nothing else is there. From there as ruled: Day 77 Tessa's screenshot, word for word; the withdrawals; Day 214; the review; the Gazette; Ally, who hears about the ashes from the sister, bitterly, in chapter 3, and never from the survivors.

6. Chapter 7: a suspect turn, honestly

By chapter 4 Ally holds, from the boat owner via the Tip Line and unaided, that "the young one" was at Violet's store at twenty past seven on the Monday morning, and carried a board between two doors. By chapter 6 she holds the panel from the two signwriters and the calling-in from the café. In chapter 7 Ruby gives her the envelope: the solicitor's covering slip and postmark. Four envelopes posted together on the Saturday, three to home addresses and one to a box number. A box is cleared first thing; home delivery came after work. One of the four held his key by seven, and the boat owner saw him use it at twenty past. The letter the four read together at nine that night had been in his hands since morning. Chapter 7 claims no more than that: the man who defended Liam every week, who told the room his own debt before anyone asked and paid the estate before it could look, deserves the investigation nobody gave him. The panel the town saw her carry and the letter never mentions, the kind line, the one sentence that did not sound like Vi: these are why the listener believes it, not proof, and Ally says so. Proof arrives where the spine has it: the arrest on Day 333, the panel on his wall, the deckhand's papers.

7. What changes, what does not

Changes this round. The loan open, the calling-in private (spine rows –2000, –120, 5, 19, 33, 47, 51, C5 Margo, B1 rows 1 to 3). One glass (row 1). The store off the books; Day 82 via Ruby (rows 82, 226). The panel shown to Brad at the store door on Day –19 (A1, C2). Brad never in her house after Day 0; his own bench and grate (rows 14, R2, R14). The packet keys off the slip. Ally hears of the ashes from the sister (structure, chapter 3).

Changes carried from earlier rounds. The premise device; the cold open's middle (section 11); chapter 1 packages 4 to 6; chapter 2 packages 2, 3, 8 and 10; chapter 7; the ashes for the board; intestacy; the sister with her own people; the meter box and her habits as the room's turn; the box number; the bare key note; terminology per v1.8. Rulings withdrawn along the way: teacher's pride; the probate engagement; "the ninth"; "starter list"; the two glasses; money kept out of the room (it is in the room, explained, and that is the point).

Does not change. The motive (the van money, called in for the fight with the sister; lent on no paper by Violet's choice; the book the only record). The panel (her alphabet, his mark) and the dosed tin as what frightened her into the store. Brad's PO box, dawn read and same-day swap (v1.7). His nine hundred days, the deckhand's papers, the vanish, the arrest under the deckhand's name on Day 333. Margo's six-week silence as the load-bearing lock, and her death. The survivors' fear of each other, the police look (row 25, R27), the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions. The notch. The two survivors' refusal to speak of what stood beside the letter.

8. The vo.3 round: ten findings and their answers (still in force)

#	Finding	Answer
1	Brad defeats the padlock on Day 0	Section 4
2	Chapter 7 is an inference from a "starter list"	Section 6: the box number; "starter list" gone
3	The machinery's scale; the tin cut; the solicitor; pride	Sections 2 and 3; pride withdrawn
4	Margo: Day 8; Day 19 to 51; Brad kills over a silence	Section 5, as reworked twice since
5	The key question; Liam's line; the arithmetic	Section 5: Day 15; Ruby's line; within a month
6	The sister and the ashes	Section 2; Day 82 via Ruby
7	Liam can contradict "he didn't ask why"	Section 3: bare fact only
8	Ruby to Del on Day 15	Row 25 and R27; either branch survives
9	"The ninth"	No date for the shelf; the letter itself is dated
10	The first minute	Section 11: a test

9. The vo.4 round: nine findings and their answers (still in force)

#	Finding	Answer
1	Margo's duty to an executor who engaged her	Never engaged; intestacy; the sister's own people
2	The suspect pool closed by assertion	Her own sentence about the spare; the one-evening audit; now also her habit of the door (section 5)
3	The fourteen days: fifth key, cutters, the book, the exposed day; the enclosure	Sections 2 and 4

#	Finding	Answer
4	No fact turns a fall into a killing	Reworked this round: the lane, the latch, her habits (section 5, Day 15)
5	Chapter 7 a suspect turn; which padlock	Section 6
6	Violet and the trade	She shows Brad last, at the store door, Day -19
7	The sister told about the ashes after Day 14	Not until Day 82, by Ruby
8	The undated letter	Dated Day -19
9	The panel's exit at 07:20	Into his own locker

10. The v0.5 round: nine findings and their answers (attack these)

#	Finding (Fable / GPT)	Answer built into v0.6
1	Margo lists the debt on Day 19 under Violet's own instruction; the Day 45 follow-up on the missing book (both drivers)	The loan was never secret; Margo lists the calling-in; Brad confirms and claims half repaid; the estate asks and Brad settles; Margo's lock is the missing book and a number nobody can test.
2	The two glasses are the author's; the man in the lane is the outsider (both)	One glass. The bridge is the lane, the latch and her habit of the door: the man was let in or let himself in, and either is one of a handful.
3	The sister's path to the store via the books (both)	Off the books, cash, no receipt; the four tell her nothing; Ruby hands over the ashes on Day 82 and the sister cuts the empty store.
4	Violet shows Brad, then what (GPT); leaf and size; the trade as police witnesses (Fable)	Shown at the store door on Day -19 as she locks it in; leaf by post; the police review never reaches the trade because nobody reported a panel.
5	The Day 14 sink (Fable)	His own bench and grate; never in her house after Day 0.
6	The packet keys (Fable)	Off the slip; in her book.
7	The solicitor's papers (Fable)	Violet's solicitor against the sister; confirms four sealed envelopes if asked, contents unknown; no branch ends.
8	The room never asks the sheds (Fable)	Nobody suspects the letter; no tampering hypothesis; Ruby drives at the house.
9	Liam asks where the van money came from (Fable)	Everyone knows.

11. The first minute: the test

Two versions of the open's middle go to the three blind readers with the ruled v0.4 open as control. Version A: she said someone had been getting in; she said it wasn't any of them; she said she might be imagining it; she wasn't; she was dead; within a month the four she trusted with the only keys were sure it was one of them; only two of them are still alive. Version B brings "only two of them are still alive" and the tin's image inside the first sixty seconds. One question at the minute mark, unprompted: what are you afraid of right now. Nothing is ruled until the readers answer.

12. The new and changed facts, swept

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
The loan is known to all four	The four	Suspect the debtor	He names it first, claims half repaid, and asks that the rest go to the estate; the letter's odd things are about someone else	Yes, if the table is written

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
Brad settles with the estate around Day 50	Sister, her accountant	Close the file	They do; an innocent man also pays promptly	Yes
Margo's reading (the book gone; the number his)	Margo	Tell the room; tell Del; tell the estate	Nothing to show but an absence and a paid debt; the man defends Liam	Yes, and it costs her
One glass	Police Day 1	Note a woman who drank alone	They do	Yes
Her habit of the door	The four	Close the pool	They do, and it is the worst thing that could have happened to them	Yes
The store off the books	Sister, her accountant	Find it	Not in anything they hold; the four say nothing; Day 82 via Ruby	Yes
The showing at the store door, Day -19	Brad	Reach the panel	He cannot; he waits for the keys	Yes
Brad never in her house after Day 0	Nº14	See him	She does not	Yes
The packet keys off the slip	Brad, from the book	Recover them	No	Yes
The trade as police witnesses	Two signwriters, the café	Volunteer a missing panel	Nobody asked; nobody reported it missing	Yes

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. This premise change has been attacked three times and reworked three times on the findings; sections 8, 9 and 10 list those findings and the answers now built in. Your job is to break the fourth cut, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full. Attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. A finding from a previous round re-raised without engaging its answer does not count; if you think an answer fails, say exactly where it fails. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

- Brad's candour.** At meeting one he tells the room his own debt, claims half repaid in cash, and later pays the estate what he named. Does a room looking for a liar let the one man with a money motive and a dead lender walk past because he spoke first? Find the line one of them says, and who says it.
- Margo's reading.** Her lock is now a missing book and a number nobody can test, arriving when the estate is paid. Find her earliest competent action after Day 50 and say what happens. Then say whether Brad can read her silence at meeting six without her having said a word about the book to him.
- One glass and her habits.** The room closes the pool on the man in the lane, the latched door and Violet's habit of never opening after dark to anyone she had not known for years. Find the outsider that habit lets in, or the reason the police could not weigh it and the room could.
- The store and the sister.** Off the books, cash, no receipt; the four tell her nothing; Ruby hands her the ashes on Day 82. Find the day before Day 14 on which anyone with a right to the estate learns the store exists.

5. **The showing at the store door.** Violet shows Brad the panel on Day -19 as she locks it in, and lodges the keys the next day. Find what a competent Brad does between Day -19 and Day 0 with that knowledge, and whether it moves Day 0.
6. **The whole.** Take the device as it now stands and find the earliest competent action by any person in the story, on any fact, that ends the episode before its time. If there is none, say so.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.